Orchha, Madhya Pradesh

As monsoon mist envelops the ancient temples and fort, the rain-drenched town of Orchha truly comes into its own. Dating back to the 16th century, it is a veritable treasure trove of architectural wonders. The fort complex has three stunning palaces, each resplendent with unique features. Inside the Raja Mahal is a temple dedicated to Lord Rama with a riveting story that makes a visit even more fascinating.

DO Visit the sanctuary around the Betwa River, where you can spot up to 200 different species of birds, local as well as migratory

EAT Try the local dessert called *Raas ki Kheer* (made of local mahua flowers, milk and millets) and other local dishes like *Bundelkhandi Gosht* at Amar Mahal

STAY MP Tourism's Sheesh Mahal heritage hotel

GO Fly to Gwalior and drive 112 km



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Wayanad, Kerala

This dark and mysterious land has always fascinated us. Clumps of golden bamboo tower overhead, allowing the sunshine to filter through sparingly. When the thunder clouds gather, Wayanad displays a beauty that is both terrific and terrifying. It's rich with coffee and spice plantations, and, being part of the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, boasts incredible biodiversity. While you should avoid a visit to Kuruvadweep, uninhabited islands filled with rare medicinal plants, during the rains, head to Banasura Sagar nearby, India's largest dam.

DO The Meenmutty falls, the biggest in the region, get even more fiercely fabulous during the monsoon

EAT Thalaserry biryani, stew with *appams* or Malabar *parotta*, or coconutty fish *moilee* with Gandhakasala rice. Try Wilton Restaurant at Sulthan Bathery and Clay-Hut, or 1980's: A Nostalgic Restaurant in Kalpetta

STAY A number of great options include Pepper Trail, Tranquil, Vythiri, and more

GO Fly to Kozhikode and drive 65 km